

- STATE OF VERMONT -

Burton Island State Park

Guide to the Interpretive

Nature Trail and Hiking Trail



written and illustrated
by Stephen Antil
Park Naturalist

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ISLAND STATE PARK: GUIDE TO THE INTERPRETIVE NATURE
TRAIL AND HIKING TRAIL ***

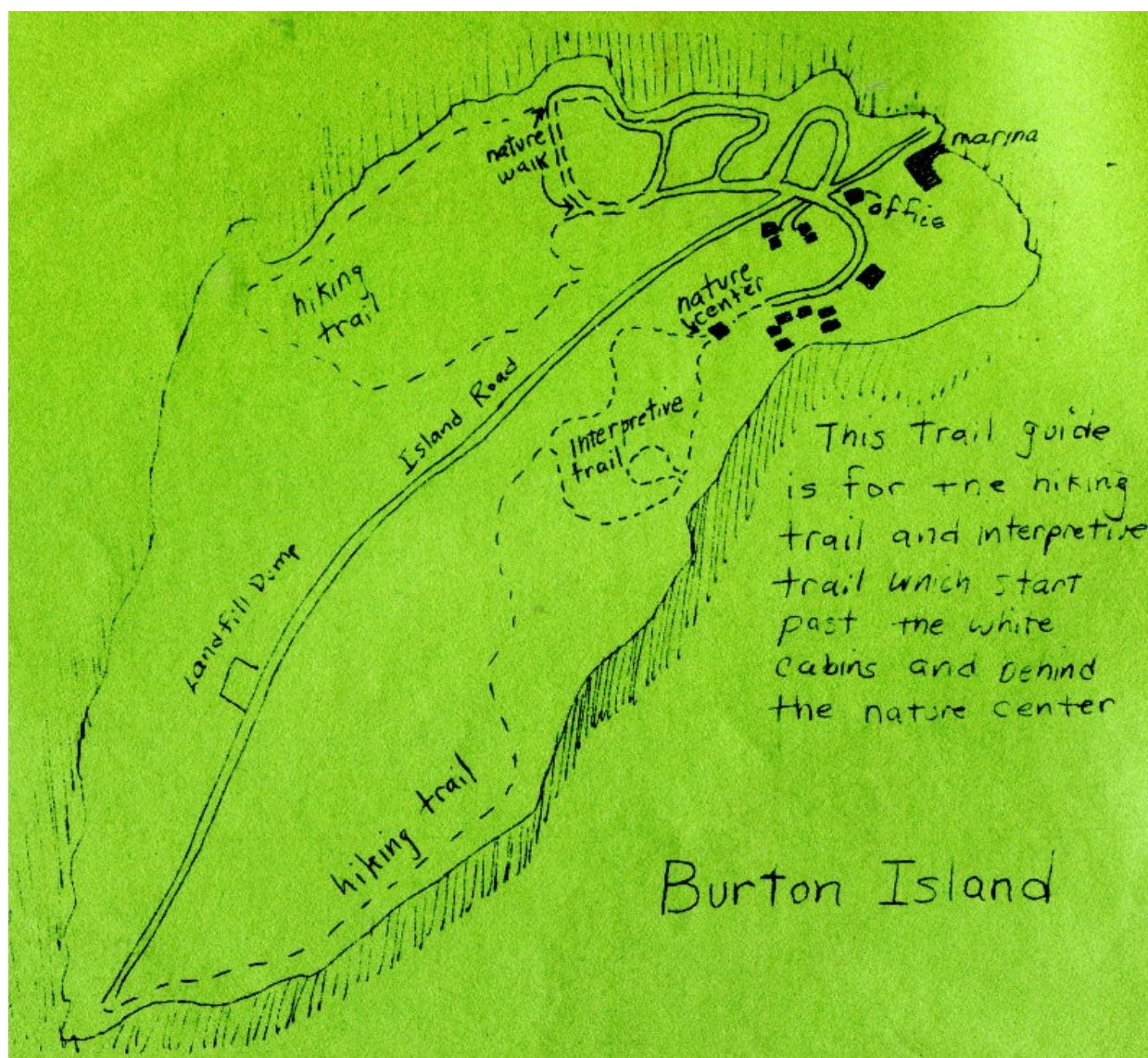
—STATE OF VERMONT—

Burton Island State Park

Guide to the Interpretive Nature Trail and Hiking Trail

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1



Burton Island

nature center
marina
office
nature walk
hiking trail
interpretive trail
Island Road
Landfill Dump

This Trail guide is for the hiking trail and interpretive trail which start past the white cabins and behind the nature center

The interpretive nature trail will take 30 minutes to walk. The numbers in this pamphlet correspond to the numbered sign posts on the trail. It is advisable that you wear shoes when walking the trails. The scenic hiking trail can be hiked in one to one and a half hours and will take you to the southeast tip of the island and back.

You can help the naturalist maintain good hiking conditions on these trails by carrying out what you carry in.

Many of Vermont's wildflowers are protected. Therefore, it is suggested that all wild flowers be left in their natural environment for the next person to enjoy.

The land surrounding Burton Island and the area of Northern Lake Champlain was once the hunting grounds of the Iroquois and Algonquin Indians. It was here that these people hunted and fished for their survival. Hunting and trapping for wolves, deer, mink and elk, and fishing for salmon, trout and bass, the Iroquois and Algonquin found an abundance of game.



(Indian agriculture)

As white men increased, agriculture began to dominate this area. In the late 1700's, Burton Island was cleared and tilled by Jesse Weldon, a settler and agent for the Allen family—Ethan, Ira and Levi.

In 1840, C.C. Burton owned the island and hired a family to live here and manage his farm.

Ida Lashaway acquired the land in 1928. During this time, the Lashaway family continued to till the land and raise livestock.

In 1944, farming operations were discontinued. From that time until the present, we have had the opportunity to see what role mother nature can play in returning the land to a natural state. The signs of farming are still here, but for the last three decades natural forces have been left relatively unchallenged.

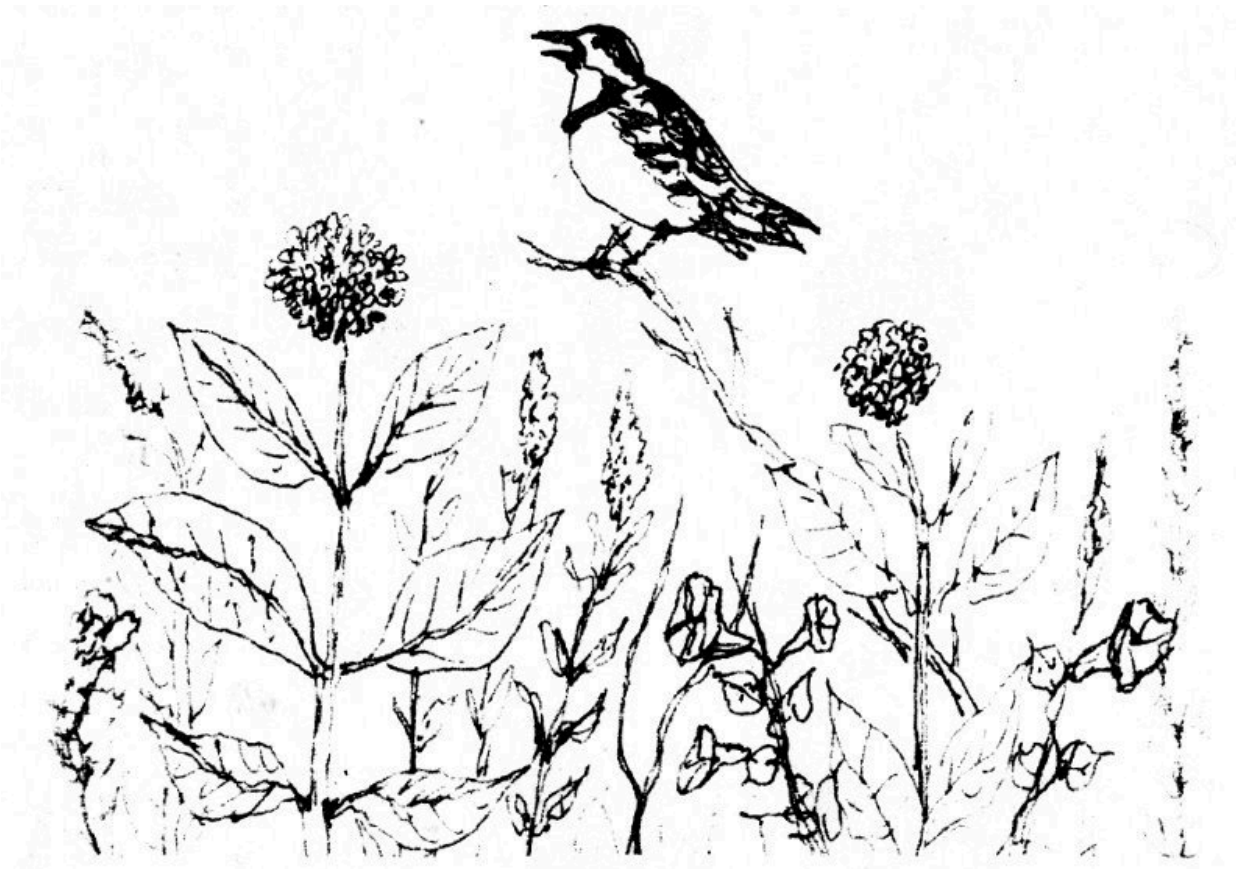
3

1

Today we can see the stories of the past and present etched across the face of Burton Island. An old farm in horse-drawn buggy days was left to the mercy of warm summer rains and icy winter storms. We can see the land, once a pasture, now swelling into overgrown fields and forests where wild plants and animals compete to live in a continually changing habitat.

2

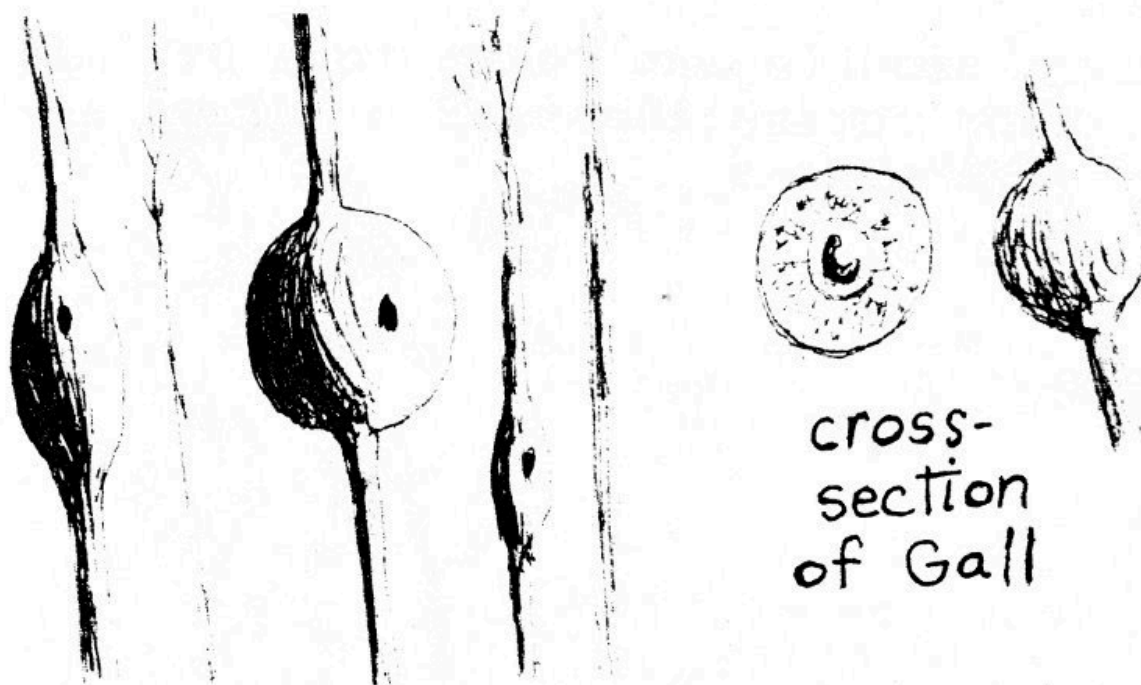
Before you lies what was formerly pasture-land. Fields exist when they are mowed or grazed. As a field is left untended, goldenrod, milkweed, morning glories and raspberry bushes appear and compete for sunlight. This is the first stage of a succession of various plants and animals passing from an old farm field into what will someday be a forest. Two common field birds found here are the meadowlark and the bobolink.



(meadowlark)

3

On the dead goldenrod stalks are round and oval-shaped outgrowths known as galls. A gall is an abnormal growth of a plant resulting from an insect or bacterial irritation. The round, one-inch galls are caused by the *Eurosta Fly*. The long, oval growths contain eggs and larvae from the *goldenrod gall moth*. Eggs were laid within the stem causing an irritation which stimulated plant cell production. A cozy home formed for the larvae. Before they developed into the flies, they ate their way out—look for the small holes in the old galls. 4



cross-section of Gall

4

The farm equipment here was used on the farm of C.C. Burton. The plow and rake were both horsedrawn. The plow broke the soil for planting, and the rake gathered hay for stacking. These implements are reminders of our heritage.

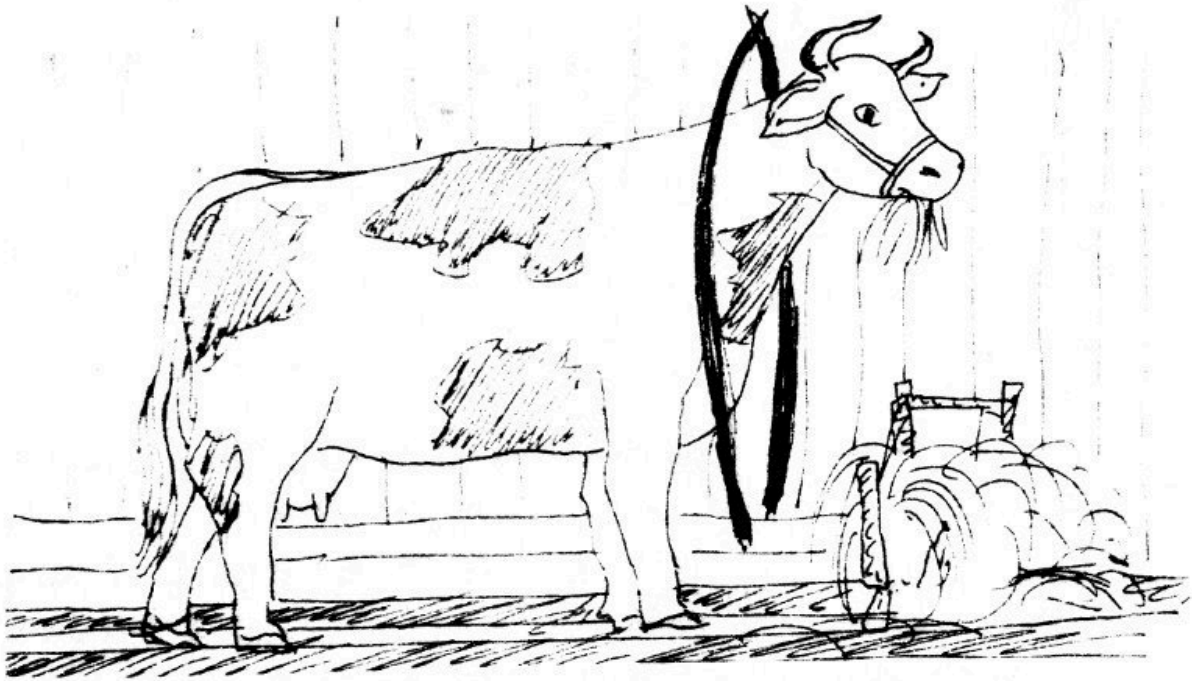
Farm life in America was hard, the tools were basic. From the simplicity of an agricultural existence close to the land, America has grown into a complex, technological country. But, our dependence on the earth is still as vital.

5

This is the foundation and remains of the barn owned by Mr. Burton in the 1800's and the Lashaway family in the early 1900's.

During the 1800's, the barn held 15 milk cows. The family that worked the farm raised 500 turkeys, 200 sheep, pigs, horses and chickens. The farm was relatively self-sufficient. The work was done with teams of horses or by hand. Ice was cut from Lake Champlain each winter and was stored in an icehouse. Cow stanchions mark where cows were once milked. Butter was churned here. Many sheep were probably shorn of their coats right where you stand. 5

All farm produce was taken to a St. Albans market either across the reef or drawn across the ice in the winter.



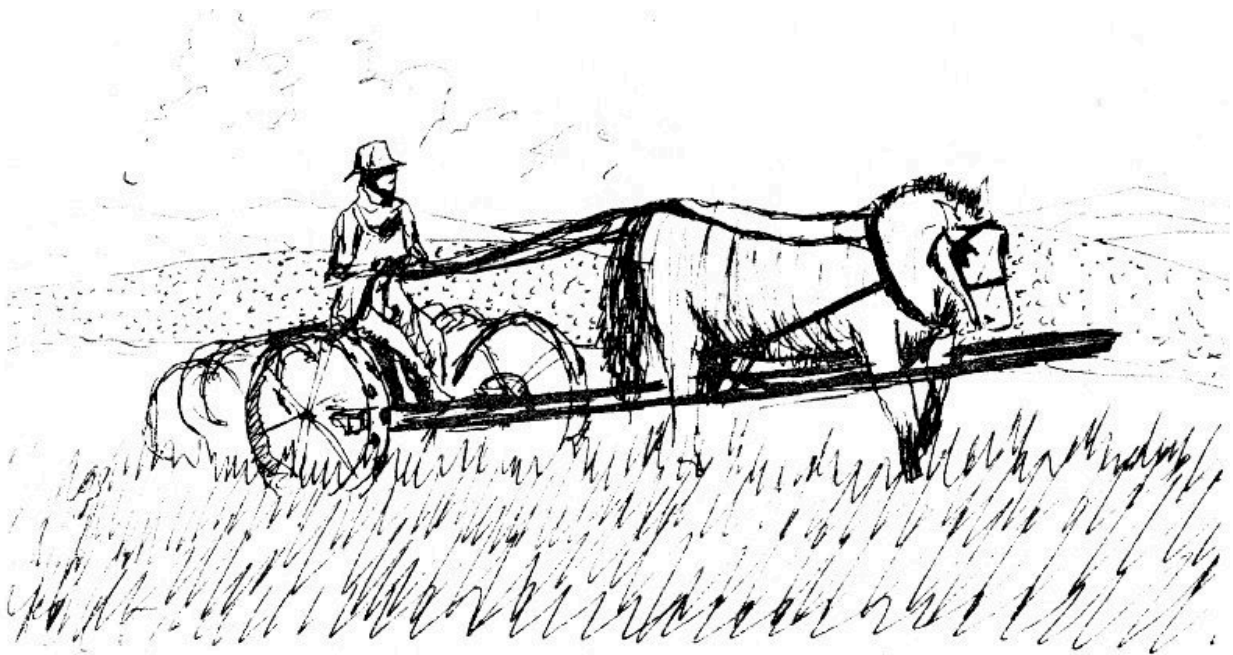
(cow stanchion)

Traces of the farm are quickly vanishing beneath the flourish of thickets and sumac.

The family managing the farm lived in the house above the foundations. The children went to school in St. Albans and travelled by boat or over ice almost every day. In the spring, when the ice was too thin to walk on but too thick for boats, it was necessary for children to board with friends on the mainland.

In 1928, Ida Lashaway and her family continued to work the farm. Through their efforts, some of the finest hay in the state was cultivated here.

Mr. and Mrs. Randall Dimon purchased the farm in 1944. Farming operations were discontinued. However, the Dimons continued to maintain some fields and raised yellow-eyed beans and hay. Several local residents of St. Albans pastured heifers as well as other livestock on the island. 6



(raking hay)

In 1961, the State of Vermont purchased the island, and the Department of Forests and Parks began operating it as a State Park.

This maple tree was blown down by high winds last summer. Heavy storms come quickly here, and trees and plants living near the shore must be especially hardy to withstand the effects of wind, water and ice. The erosive actions of these forces cause the shore to be battered and worn like a seacoast.

The downed maple will continue living as long as part of its root structure can supply the tree with water and nutrients and as long as its leaves can embrace the rays of the sun. In years to come, the branches may 7 eventually become trunks themselves, growing upward and thickening into individual trees with one massive base.

8

In fields, grasses and small brush soon yield to shrubs and small trees such as sumac and hawthorne. These plants are the start of the forest and begin to limit the light striking the earth. Plants such as goldenrod and raspberry depend on light for their survival. Unable to obtain it, they are suppressed.



(sumac and hawthorne)

Hawthorne were rare trees in the virgin forests of America, but with the clearing of forests, they became common. Today they are found in fields, along fence rows and in small clusters, for they are fond of the sun. The dense, thorny branches create a crown which is almost impregnable. The trees provide excellent nesting sites for many kinds of songbirds due to the excellent protection the trees give their occupants.



Blackburnian Warbler

orange head

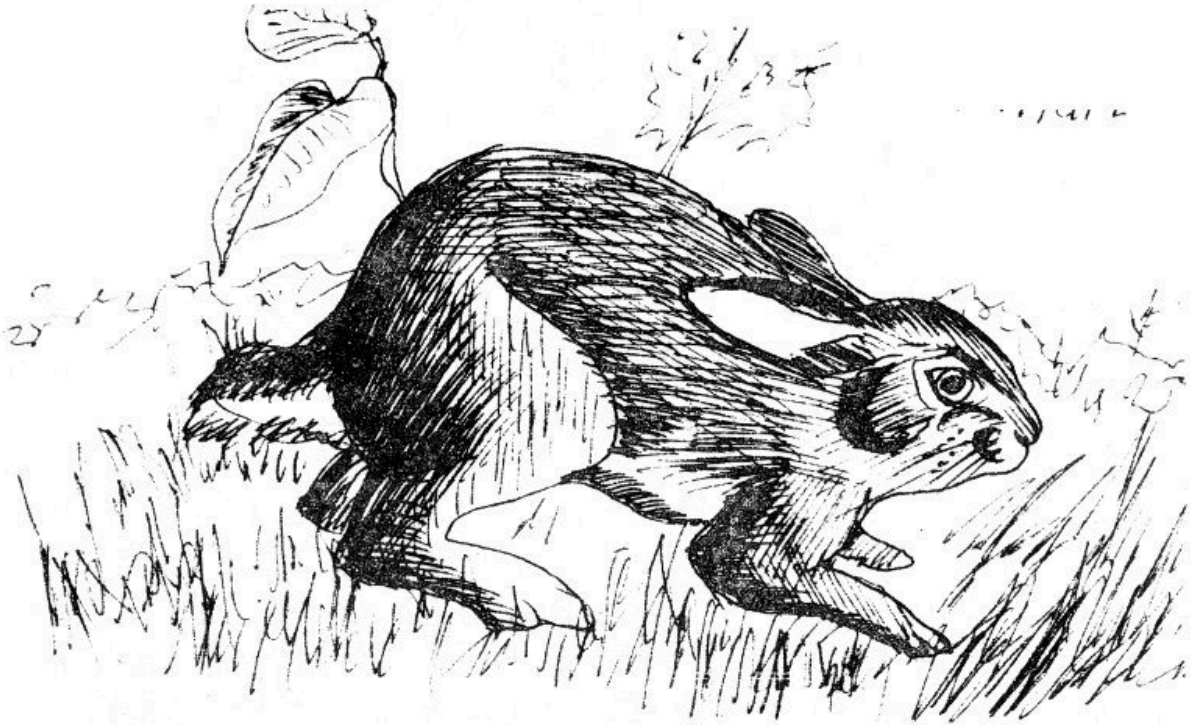
9

This dead, old hawthorne has served as a home for many animals. Over a period of years, the tree has rotted and has been occupied by fungi, carpenter ants and beetles. This drew hungry woodpeckers which have tapped holes in the tree in search of food. Gradually, the tree has been hollowed out. Birds and chipmunks probably have used the tree for hiding or nesting.



white-breasted nuthatch

When we stepped out of the shady cluster of shrubby trees into this clearing, did you notice the drastic change in the kind of vegetation? Raspberry brambles crowd each other for sunlight. Where there is no canopy to limit sunlight, a brushy habitat abounds. You may see some special wildlife here—bird, rabbit and fox.



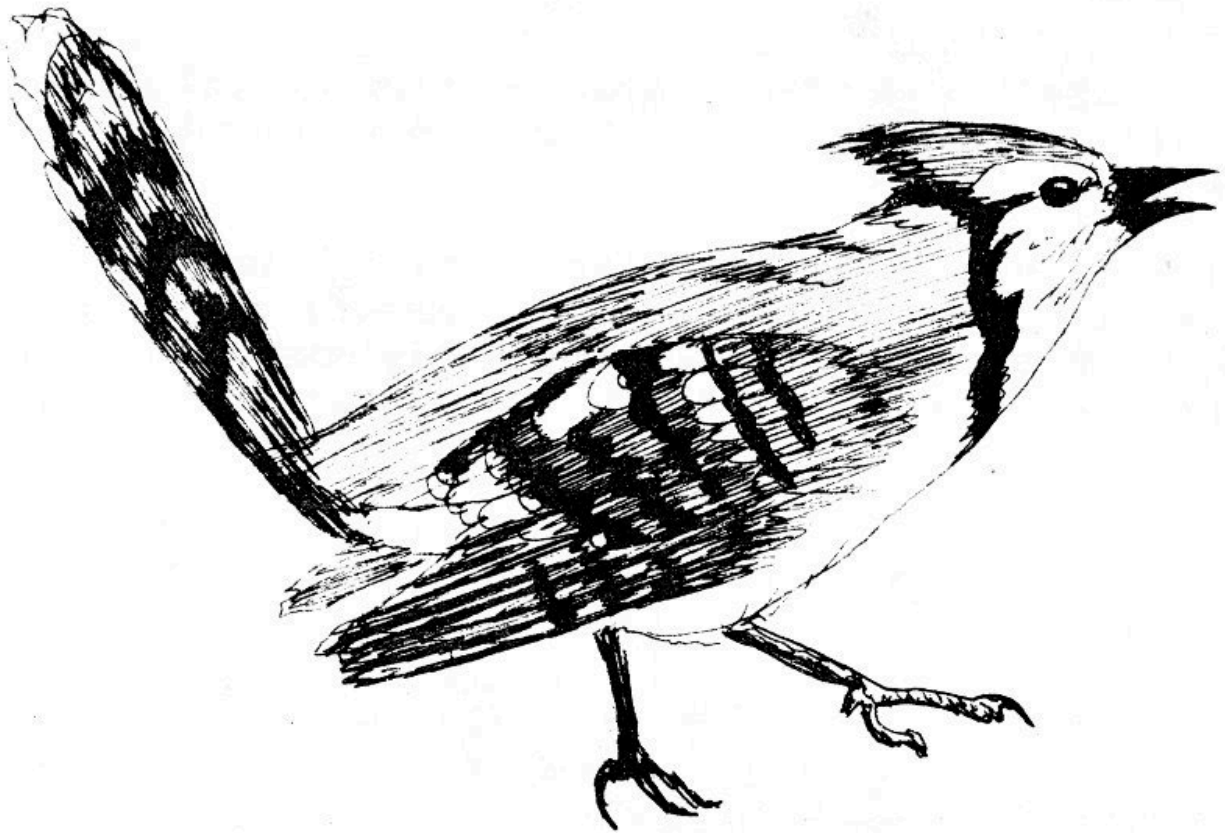
cottontail

11

We are now standing under a canopy of white cedar and poplar. The young saplings growing on this forest floor are maples and hickories. These young hardwoods enjoy living in the shade. Their need for sunlight is not great. Eventually, these saplings will outgrow the aspen and cedars. When that day comes, a forest of maples and hickories will restrict sunlight from penetration. The cedars and aspen will die.

12

These beautiful sugar maples have large crowns which shade an extensive area. Plants needing sunlight cannot grow beneath the large trees. The skeletons of dead cedars demonstrate that species' inability to get sunlight and compete with the maples. In this habitat, raccoons, nuthatches, squirrels and bluejays are commonly found.



(bluejay)

13

This maple tree was tapped for its sap many years ago. Can you see the tap holes? These holes have been partially grown over and have healed.



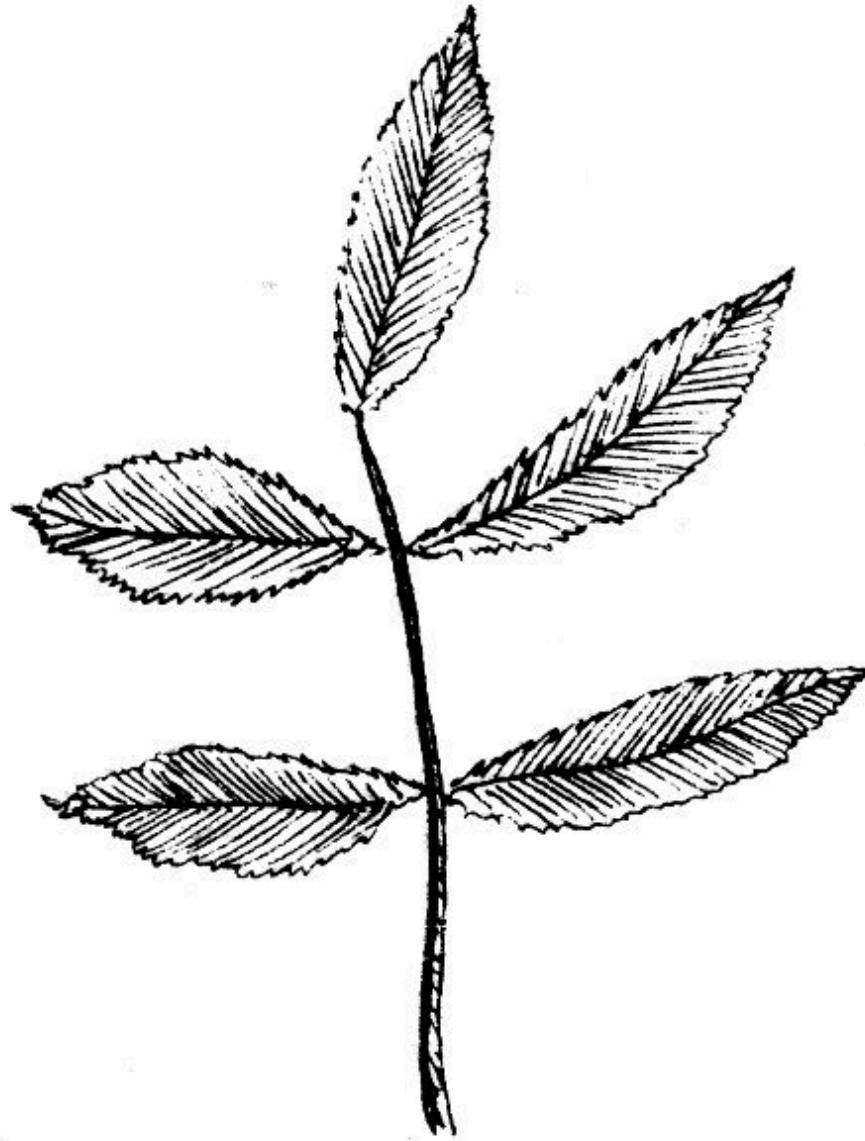
(tapping maple tree for sap)

14

This ancient shagbark hickory has actually grown around the rusted barbed wire left from the old farm. Cows from Mr. Burton's farm probably lingered beneath the tree to find relief from the hot sun. This tree is over 150 years old.

11

Hickory wood is particularly strong, heavy and flexible and was used for manufacturing agricultural tools—most commonly axe handles, and spokes and rims for wagon wheels.



Shagbark Hickory

15

At this point, you have the opportunity of continuing either upon the remainder of the interpretive nature trail or upon the scenic hiking trail. The shorter interpretive loop turns to the right and contains stations [16](#) through [19](#) which may be followed on the next several pages.

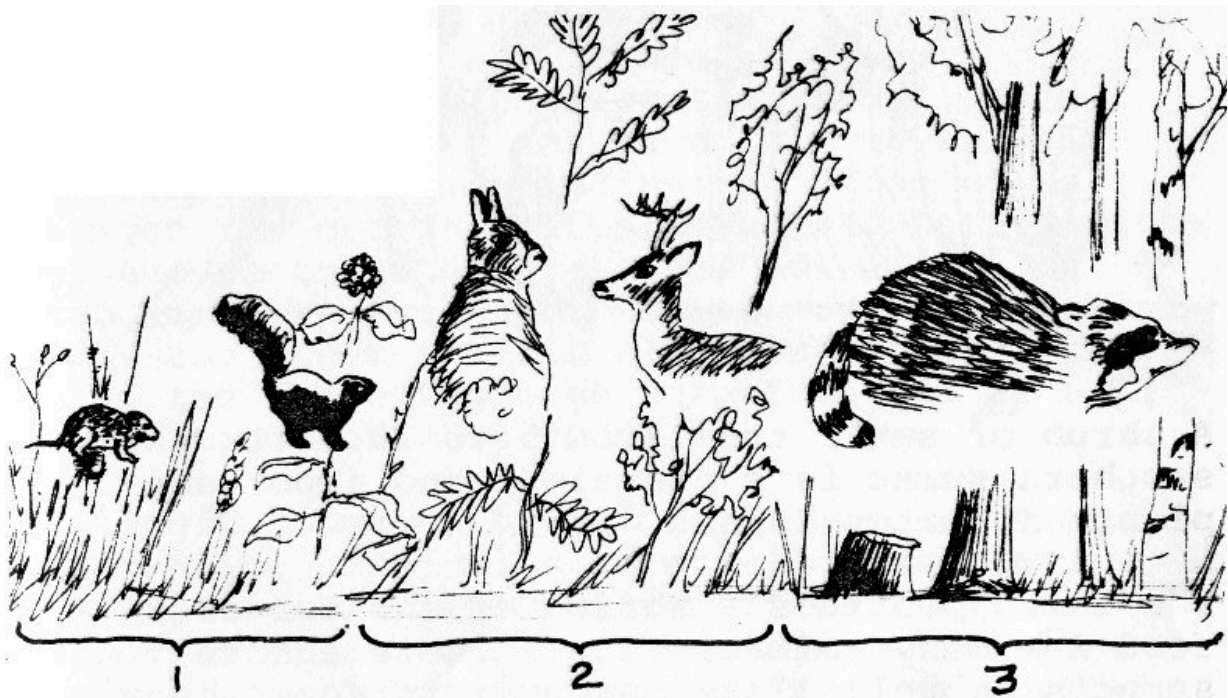
Should you decide upon the scenic hiking trail, follow the trail markers to your left. This trail runs to the end of the island and along some beautiful vistas of Lake Champlain. Turning to [page 14](#), you will find a brief guide which we hope will bring to your attention many of the interesting features along this path.

12

16

This is one of the highest points on the island. Look around you. We have seen the changes from field to bramble patches, from shrubby clusters to large trees making up a forest habitat. This is natural succession, the change from field to forest. With this change of plants comes the change of animals, for animals and plants depend on each other and form a natural community.

The serenade of piping birds, the rhythmic waves of Champlain, the whispering trees—these sounds cannot help but deepen our appreciation and enjoyment of the forest. Close your eyes and listen peacefully.



- 1—annuals, perennials
- 2—shrubs, trees
- 3—climax forest

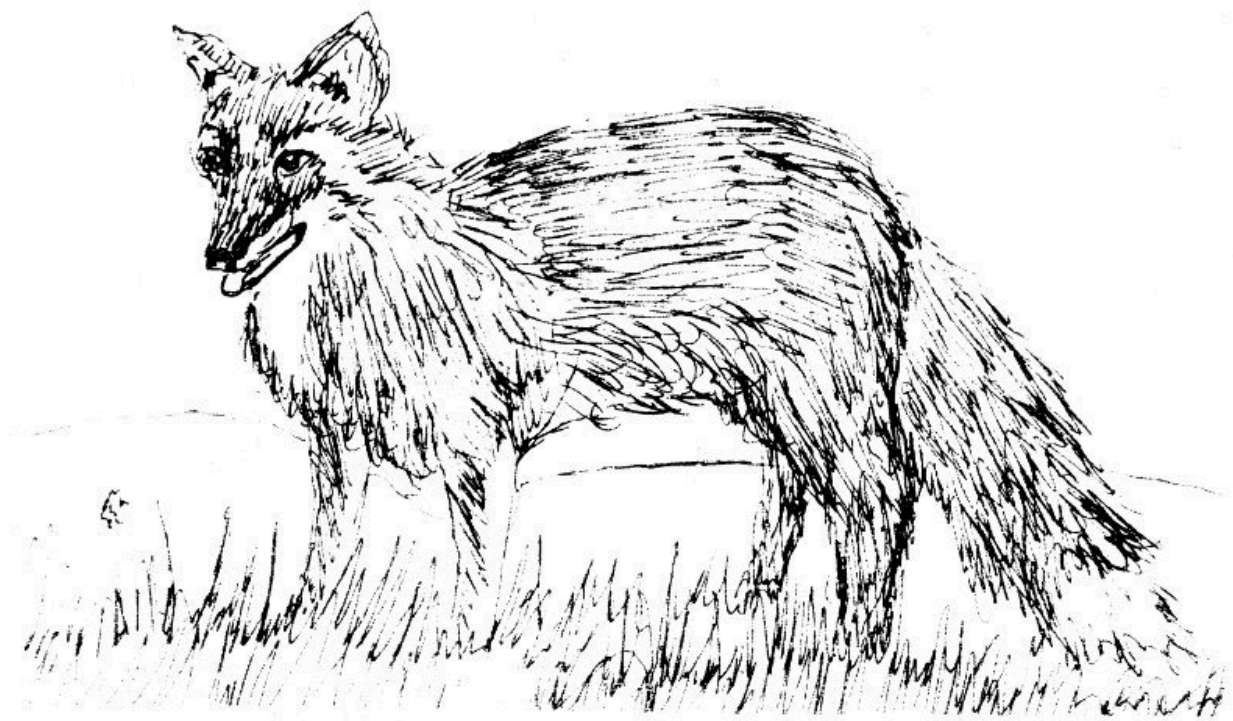
17

The area before you is moist and marshy. As you can see, plants growing here differ a great deal from those in dryer, hillier regions of the island. Sweet Flag (leaves like Cattails) is a dominant plant here.

18

This pathlike gully was once a drainage ditch leading to the marshy meadow. Foxes have been using them as passageways when navigating through the brush in search of food.

Red fox prefer to live on the edges of fields or in open country. 13
Meadow mice are probably the number one food item of the fox.
Young foxes consume large numbers of beetles, grasshoppers and crickets.
They eat all types of berries, melons and corn.

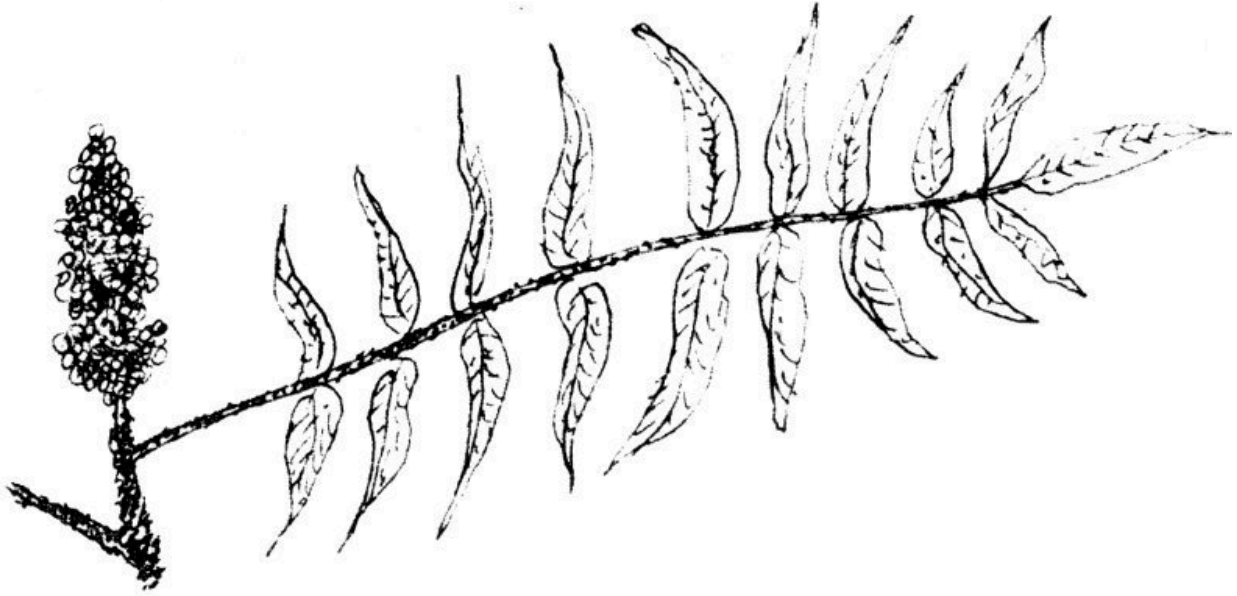


(red fox)

19

A shrub or small tree from 5 to 20 feet, the staghorn sumac is a prevalent and important plant on Burton Island.

The sumac provides a source of shelter and food for many animals here. The staghorn sumac's umbrella-like canopy furnishes shade to birds in the hot days of summer. It serves as a refuge during rain storms. Birds can easily disappear in the maze of leaves and branches in time of danger. The pink berry-like clusters of blossoms offer food for birds. Later, the fruits become dry and they may persist for a year or so providing an emergency food for squirrels and birds. The deer and cottontail rabbit find the twigs and bark a most acceptable meal during the winter. In former years, the sumac was often used for tanning fine leathers and as a dye because of high 14 content of tannic acid.

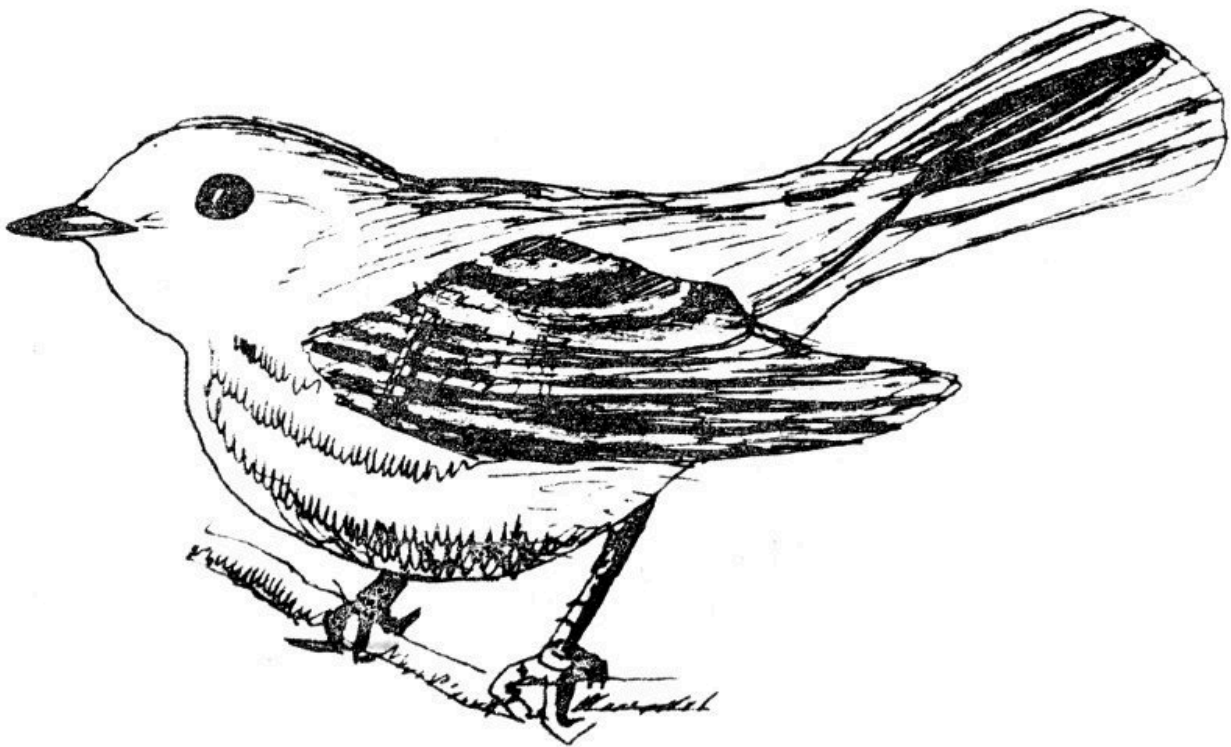


Staghorn Sumac

HIKING TRAIL

Unlike the shorter interpretive trail, this scenic hiking trail has been left relatively undisturbed by human influence. Most of us have so few opportunities to behold nature without the contrivances of a busy civilization that here we have attempted to minimize signs, rails and other artificial hiking aides. Therefore, the following pages are included as a brief guide for this trail.

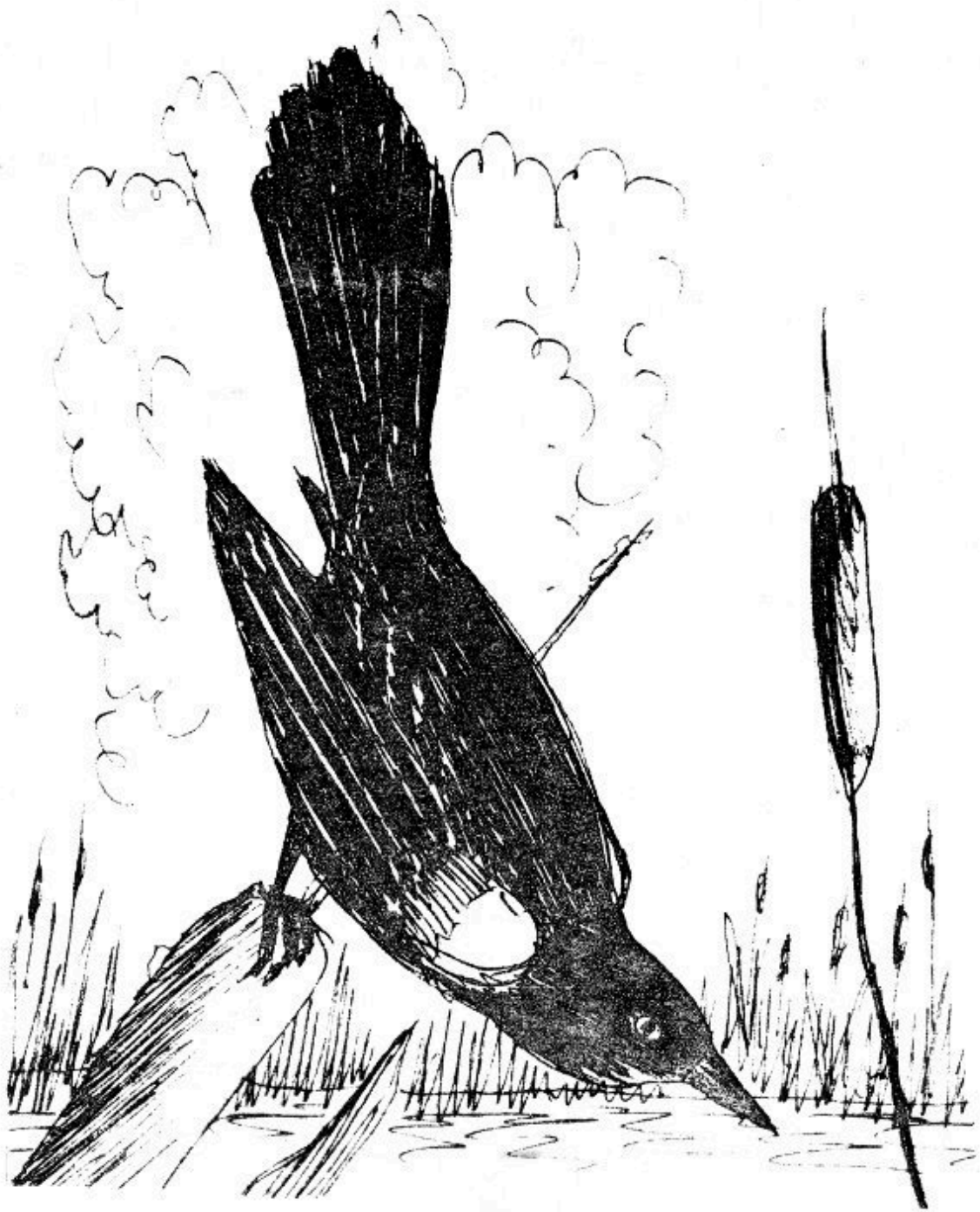
Walking through this field, you may see a yellow canary-like bird called the yellow warbler. The male warbler is brilliantly marked ... its yellow body with striped red breast is like a flash of sunlight as the bird darts in and out of the greenery.



yellow warbler

There are over one hundred different kinds of warblers in the United States and they are all four to six inches long. Because of their great variety and the brilliance of their coloring, they have been called the “butterflies of the bird world.” 15

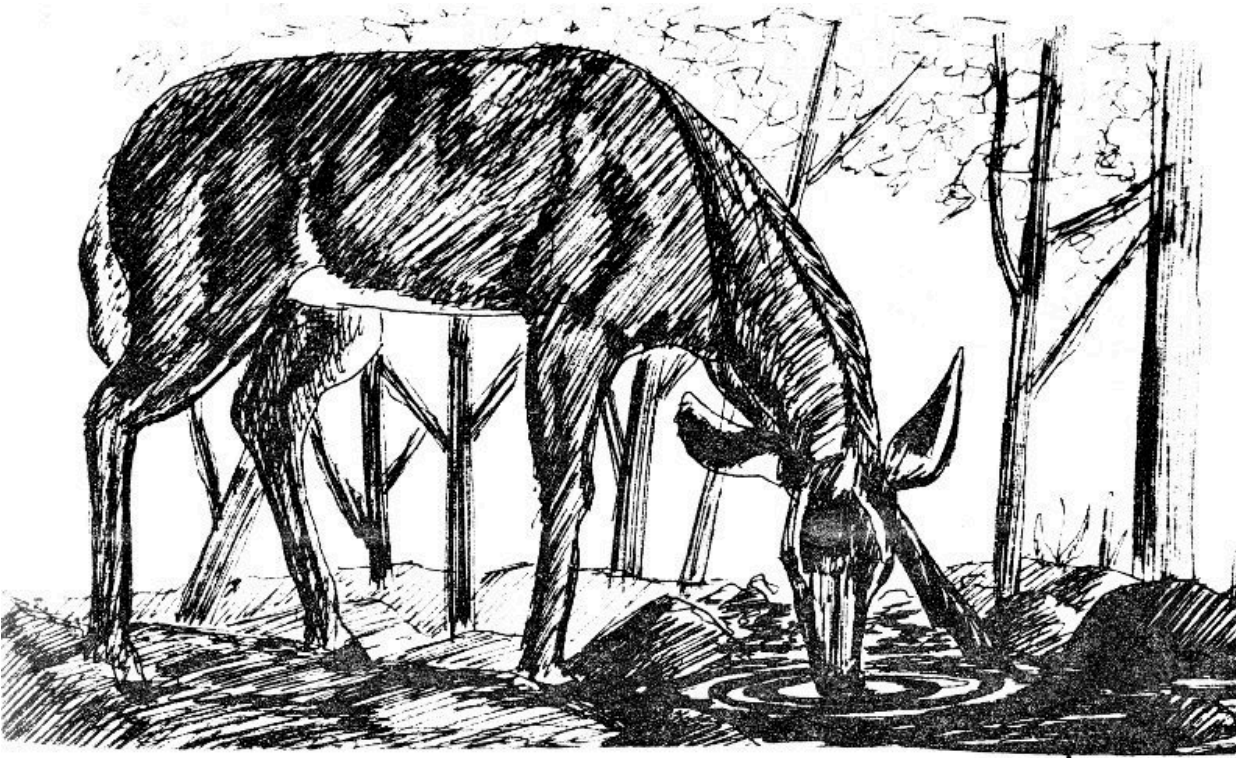
By now, you have probably seen the red-winged blackbirds. These birds are found commonly on Burton Island. Red-wings love marshes and wet fields. They make their nest close to the ground where it is hidden by reeds, grasses and shrubs. The birds will sit on branches of small trees and watch intently as you walk by. The red-wings call out many interesting sounds, from a raspy “oka-fleek, oka-fleek” to a warning “chuk, chuk.” The black birds, with their fiery shoulders, let us know that we are trespassing on their territory.



(red-winged blackbird)

As you enter the forest of young elms, you will notice how the atmosphere changes. Light is dim. The importance of sunlight is obvious, for no plants are to be found growing on the forest floor.

Sixty yards beyond the entrance to the elm forest, a circular growth of young plants reach for sunlight. An opening in the forest canopy allows these plants to live. The area of direct sunlight is shown by the size and shape of the growing vegetation. These openings provide food for browsing animals such as deer.



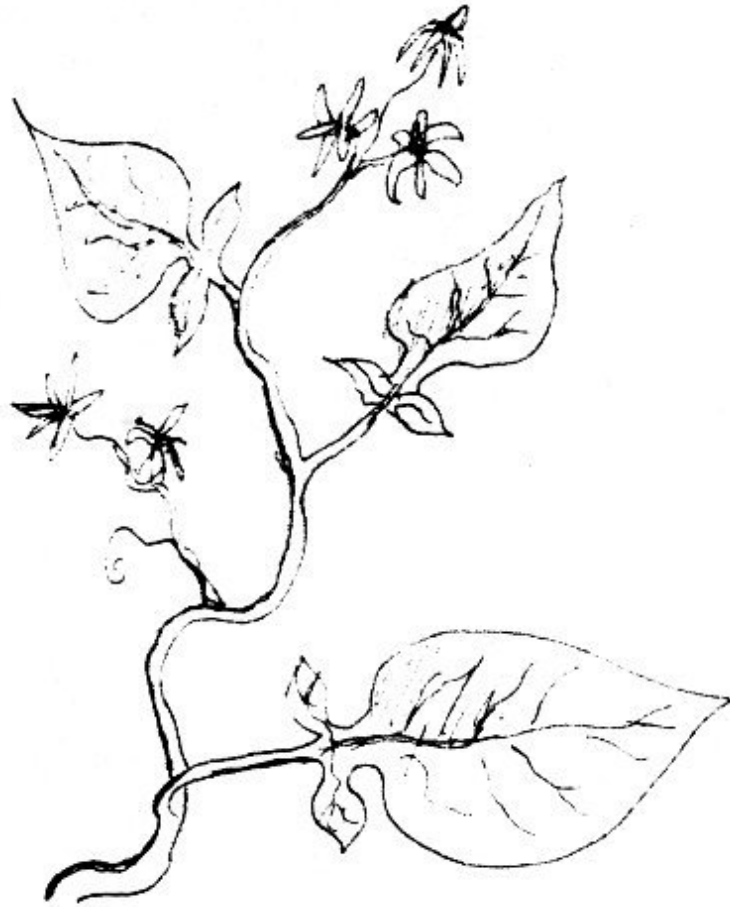
(deer)

Look upon the shady, almost plantless floor, you may see mushrooms and indian pipes popping up through the dead leaves. Unlike green plants which need sunlight to manufacture their own food, these saprophytes obtain food from the dead plants they grow on. Some mushrooms grow upon fallen logs and branches. Some grow in the soil using the dead plant matter there for food. Indian pipes are one of the few flowering plants that are saprophytes.



Indian Pipes and mushrooms

As you continue along the trail, keep your eyes open for vines which have wrapped themselves around tall trees to reach the sun. This adaptation allows a green plant to be rooted in the darkness of the forest, but to grow in the sunny upper reaches of the forest canopy. This vine is called bittersweet (nightshade).



Bittersweet (Nightshade)

A stone fence runs across the trail. This old fence once restricted the range of sheep on the island. Blood, sweat, tears and long hours must have gone into piling these stones, for the fence runs across the entire island.

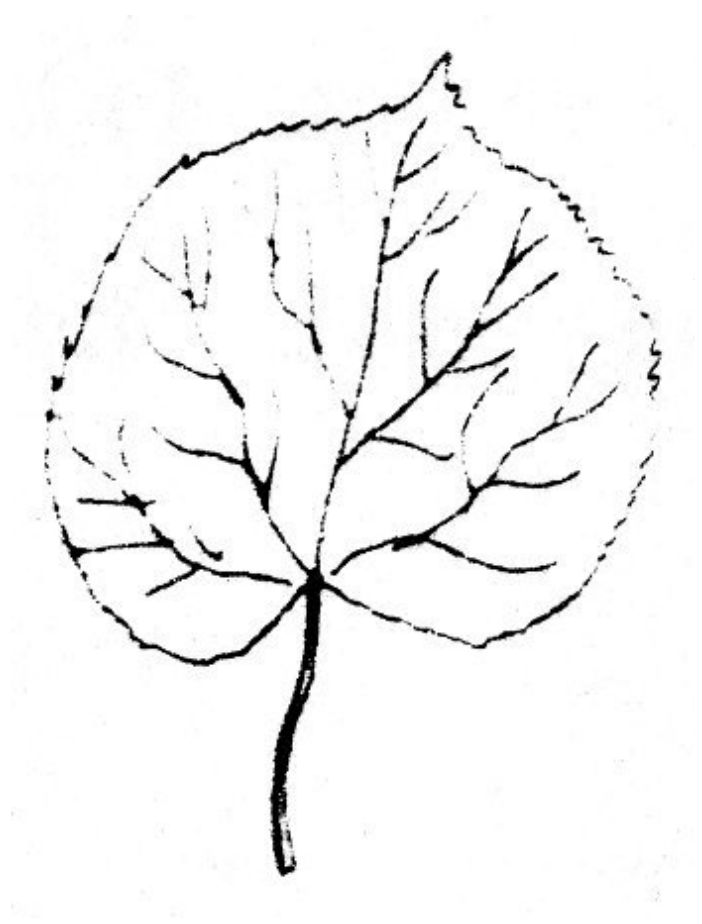


(building a stone fence)

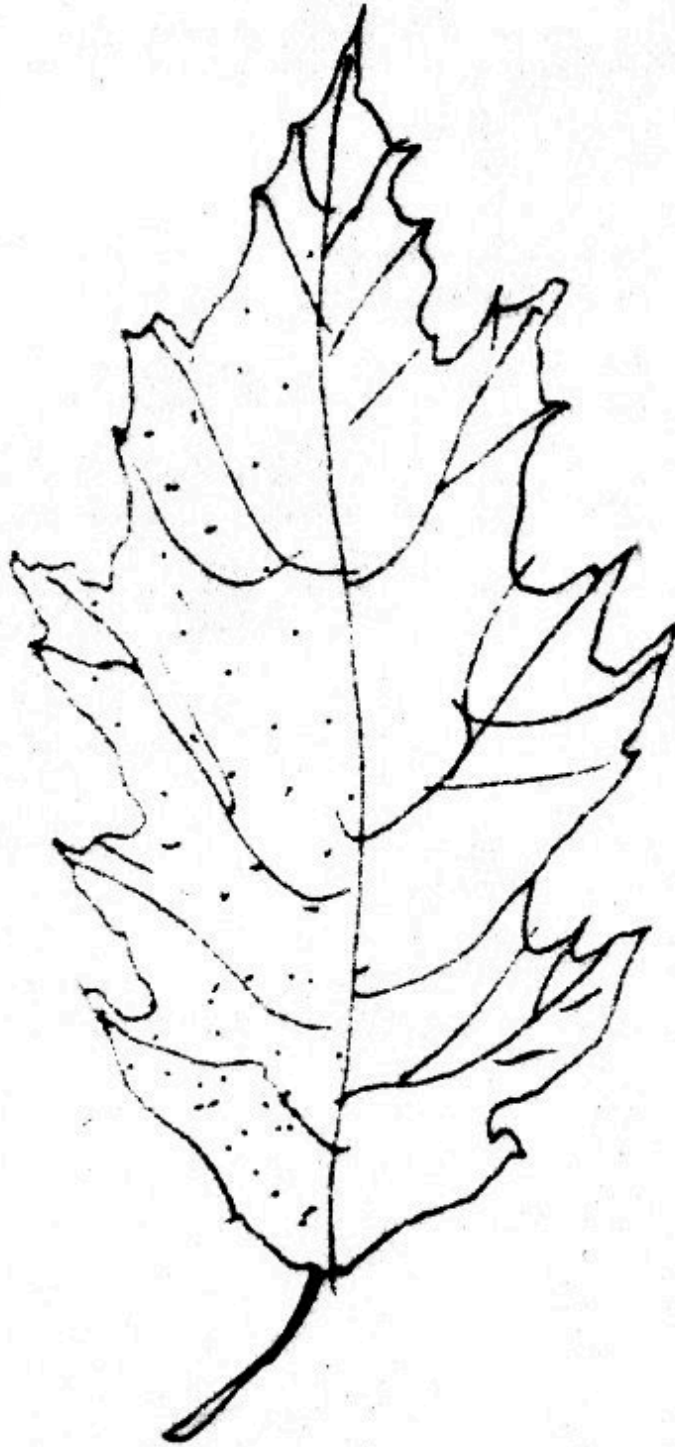
An old, dead tree stands by the wall. This tree is important for it offers shelter to thousands of insects and provides a source of food for hungry birds.

The shelf fungi growing on the tree extract nutrients from the decaying wood.

As you walk along the lakeshore, look at some of the larger trees growing there. Two common trees you will see are basswood and red oak.



Basswood



Red Oak

The American Basswood grows 70-80 feet in height and 2-3 feet in diameter. In addition to the valuable timber which it produces, the

basswood is highly prized in certain localities for its honey. The Iroquois Indians made rope from the bark by soaking it in water for several weeks or months to allow the nonfibrous portions to rot. Then it was twisted into desired cords.

The northern red oak is one of the largest oaks, occasionally 125 feet high. Its close-grained, reddish-brown wood is regarded as one of the most important of the red oak family.

As you hike you will see blown down trees. These rotting trees show us that nature wastes nothing. Fungi, bacteria, insects and weather are helping to decay these blowdowns. The resulting humus is a natural soil fertilizer readily available to growing plants.

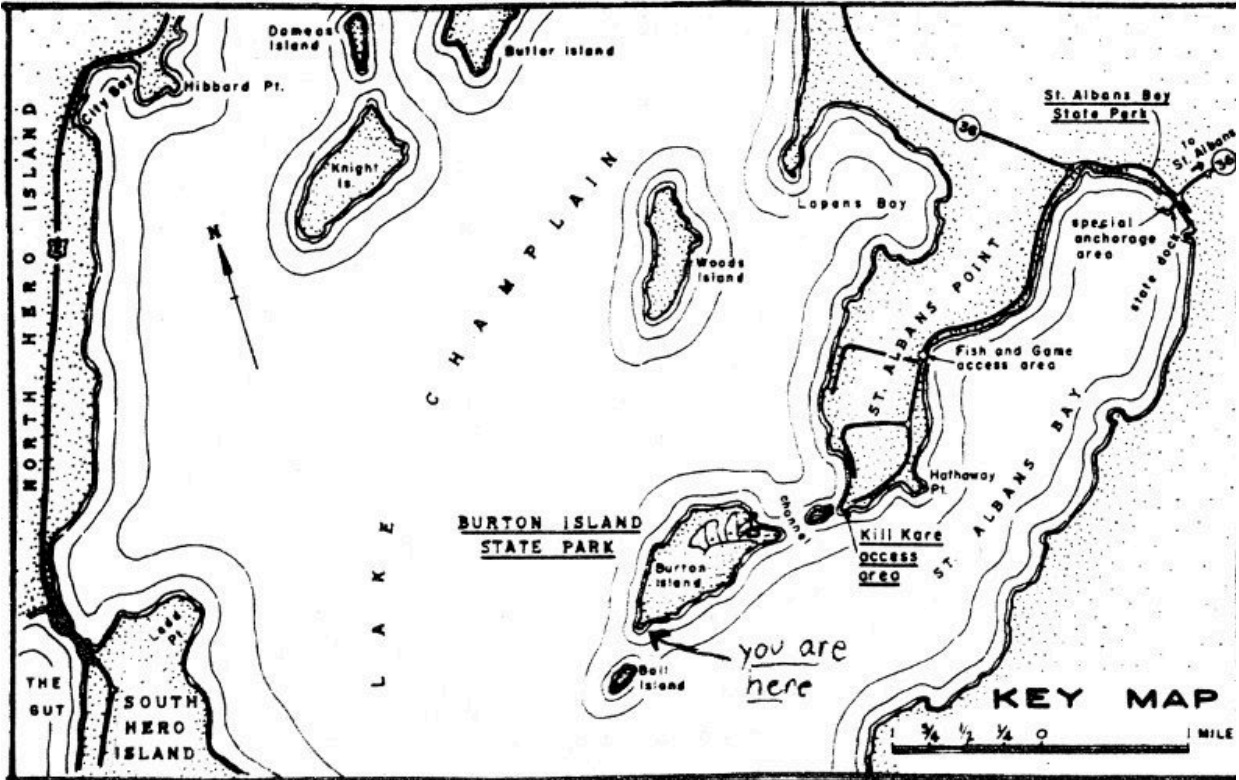
During the last ice age, a huge body of water called Lake Vermont spread from the Green Mountains to the Adirondacks and from Canada to Rutland, Vermont. Mud and stones from the lake have been compressed for thousands of years since, forming great rock beds. Along the shoreline of Burton Island, sheets of rock and flat stones are numerous. Once the shore and bottom of Lake Vermont, these huge beds of shale and sandstone are now eroding.

On the southern tip of Burton Island, old and gnarled cedar trees reach out. The roots of these trees hold firm against the erosive action of wind, rain and ice.



Landscape

Looking out toward the horizon, the expansive views bring the ocean to mind. Ball Island stands out in front of the jagged peaks of the Adirondacks and the flats of Sandbar. Do you know the islands around you?



KEY MAP

We at Burton Island State Park hope you have enjoyed this short hike. To return to the start, you can follow the park road or follow the hiking trail back.

21

* * * * *

This trail is part of the Vermont State Parks' Nature Interpretation Program. The program is intended to spark awareness, concern and an appreciation for the works of nature. All life is unified through the cycles and interrelationships of nature. People have the responsibility to act in a life-supporting manner toward their environment. Hopefully, through understanding, people will strive to respect and protect the delicate balances which make the earth our healthy home.

* * * * *

STATE OF VERMONT
Agency of Environmental Conservation

Department of Forests and Parks

July 1975

-NOTES-

23



(view across the lake)

Transcriber's Notes

- Silently corrected a few typos.
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- In the text versions only, text in italics is delimited by _underscores_.

***** END OF THE PROJECT GUTENBERG EBOOK BURTON ISLAND
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